France, the UK, Belgium, the Netherlands, erstwhile Czechoslovakia, erstwhile East and West Germany, Austria, Switzerland and Italy. A day or two after the Berlin Wall fell, we happened to drive into Berlin. There was chaos and confusion all over. The police, customs or border control personnel were nowhere to be seen. Like everyone else, we also tried to chip away a piece of the famous wall. We succeeded in doing that and preserved that piece for many years, till one of our orderlies threw it away thinking it was junk!

I recall a discussion between my son Vivek and me in a camp in Spain. He said he wanted to join the army and continue the family tradition. I said it was a fine idea, but he needed to bear in mind that as he rose higher, he would lose out on the age factor by a year or two, because of changing so many schools and having moved to Algeria. He could lay the blame squarely on me for that. Besides, I said, 'there aren't going to be wars in the future, only low-intensity conflicts. It might be a century where economic wars are going to be fought. So, why don't you consider being an economic warrior for the country?' That is what he is doing today.

We happened to be in Algeria when Pakistani President Zia-ul-Haq's plane crashed mysteriously on 17 August 1988. On that day there was a children's party and my son and daughter were at the house of a friend whose father was an ambassador. All of a sudden, there was commotion there. My son found out the cause and informed me. In turn, I apprised our ambassador of Zia-ul-Haq's death. This was about two hours before the BBC broke the story. Our ambassador was very impressed with my networking. Only this time I didn't reveal my source! Vivek got a nice treat from me for his alertness and presence of mind.

Another memorable event at the end of our stay in Algiers was an exhibition of paintings by Rohini. The theme was the people of Algeria. The ambassador, C.P. Ravindranathan, was not only kind enough to inaugurate the exhibition, but also included it as one of the activities of the mission for the year. The Algerians were warm to us – they loved India because of our moral and diplomatic support to them during their freedom struggle; they also loved our food, music and films. The Algerians would do anything to acquire